How to Ruin Your Life with Style
A Self-Help Manual

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TAKING PLEASURE IN THE MISFORTUNES OF OTHERS

There exists a mean but effective form of relief — as ignoble as it is profoundly human — that rarely features in treatises on emotional maturity: to include it would oblige too many people to recognize themselves in the elevator mirror. It is not about resolving one's own uncertainty entirely, nor about facing the opacity of the future with dignity, still less about renaming the disaster. It is about something more accessible: the private suspicion that, however glacial one's own prospects, the neighbor's will always be capable of reaching a temperature closer to absolute zero.

Comparative relief is not malice; it is thermal regulation. Not elegant, but effective: what dignity disapproves of in public and makes use of in private. An emergency heating system. When one cannot improve one's material or emotional circumstances, there remains the possibility of worsening other people's lot in imagination and enjoying the contrast. If one's life is a quagmire, it only takes the neighbor's to sink a few inches deeper for our mud to feel like solid ground.

Happiness, without the unfortunate on the landing, is a number without units. Misfortune works the same way: it is weighed, compared and lined up alongside other people's. There are those who open the newspaper at the obituaries —

that intimate meteorology of the neighborhood: another one gone today; we are still here. Comparative consolation offers no solutions. It offers something better: the certainty that the neighbor has none either. Things need not go well for us; it is enough to hear him roll down a longer staircase. Uncertainty will not tolerate a vacuum: if I am in the dark, I need the lights to go out across the whole building.

One leafs through the Sunday supplement, checks one's phone or summons family memory, and searches — with irreproachable manners — for a biography dealt a worse hand than one's own. A more humiliating dismissal, a divorce with broken crockery, an inheritance converted into litigation, a New Year's Eve photograph where the mascara has run with a brutal sincerity. Then the fear that five minutes earlier was floating without a dossier lets itself be archived. It acquires names, furniture, neighborhoods, court dates, glasses of whisky, sleeping pills on the bedside table. We do not always want a way out; sometimes a scale is enough. We want to know who is worse off, at what exact distance, and whether there is still a landing between their ruin and our living room.



Jefferies, the photographer laid up with an injury in *Rear Window*, inhabits a forced confinement and quickly

discovers that a telephoto lens is the best substitute for any hope of improvement. The plaster cast on his leg fixes him to the armchair like another piece of the apartment: an action photographer reduced to furniture, a girlfriend too perfect, a New York August that obliges one to leave the windows open and too much time to look.

His coming days are a succession of night sweats and neighbors' noises. The clever thing is to peer into other people's lives and look for someone else's misprints. He does not observe out of philanthropy. Not even out of curiosity. He looks out of sheer moral survival. Each window giving onto the courtyard is a dose of comparison. He needs other people's lives to be ridiculous, wretched or morally suspect. The future may be a blank full of plaster cast, but at least he has not chopped up his wife and carried her out in suitcases from the apartment opposite. The other man's fire warms his cold room a little. Curiosity is not love of knowledge: it is a form of self-defense.

Hitchcock builds Jefferies a stage set for comparative consolation: a studio Greenwich Village, raised window by window so that each vignette might offer its small private combustion. Miss Lonelyhearts lays the table for an imaginary man; Miss Torso distributes smiles, rehearses steps and tolerates suitors; the composer hammers away at the same melody. Even the couple with the little dog offers that matrimonial sadness of terrace and electric fan. Jeff

watches all of it with a glass and a cigarette. His wheelchair ceases to feel like a punishment the moment the whole courtyard organizes itself into a museum of defective futures.

Then Thorwald appears — the probable murderer from the apartment opposite — and the mechanism is refined. It is no longer simply a matter of others being unfortunate, but of one of them embodying the worst imaginable conjugal future. The ailing wife, the heat clinging to the walls, the repeated arguments, the saw, the rope, the sample cases: suddenly marriage ceases to be for Jeff an abstract threat and becomes a small hell very well ventilated by criminal suspicion. What a relief: with that prospect before him, the comparison for once works in his favor.



In *The Apartment*, C.C. Baxter lives in a limbo of corporate servitude, lending his key to bosses in search of adventures in the hope that promotion will wash away the trail of filth left by each nocturnal visit in his bed. He is a small man in an immense office, a number waiting to be promoted in exchange for his decency. His future depends on the will of men who see him only as a facilitator of infidelities, a doormat with aspirations to a private office.

Baxter does not enjoy his situation; he endures it because he measures it against a more frightening misery: remaining in

the communal room forever, among rows of identical desks, watching others rise by elevator toward floors where authority appears to have its own carpeting. He despises those executives when he sees them at close quarters — hollow, cruel, morally bankrupt — yet he still wants to resemble them. Revulsion does not cancel ambition: it makes it murkier. Every cold, every wait on a freezing bench, every neighbor who takes him for a libertine, every guest who leaves his bed disordered, seems acceptable if in the end it allows him to escape organized mediocrity.

Only later does the apartment begin to function as a moral observatory. Baxter memorizes schedules with the discipline of a clerk and contemplates the residue his superiors leave behind: cologne, ash, half-empty bottles, wounded women, promises that cost him nothing. His visitors arrive with a hat and authority; they leave converted into small men. Poverty is still poverty, the cough still sits in his chest, the professional future still smells of the elevator; but authority, seen from his apartment, no longer commands respect.

In the end he will prefer to be a *mensch*: not a better-placed employee, but a human being who has stopped measuring himself by comparison.



Baxter operates in a building. Marlowe operates in an entire city, which is the same thing but with more moral humidity and fewer prospects of promotion. There, uncertainty is not an accident: it is the climate itself. The protagonist of *noir* does not aspire to fulfillment, nor to happiness, nor even to survival in the long run; he aspires to remain upright while the ground disintegrates beneath his feet. To endure that permanent instability he needs a truth to serve as his anchor: that the whole world is a sewer.

Philip Marlowe, private detective accustomed to entering houses where no one wants to switch on the light, enters the mansions of *The Big Sleep* — those Pasadena houses with eucalyptus gardens and the discreet scent of old money — and discovers that wealth is nothing more than an expensive perfume for covering the smell of putrefaction. General Sternwood receives him in the greenhouse because he can no longer bear the cold, surrounded by orchids too humid and a fortune that has produced two daughters and no way out. The high society he serves is as degraded, as full of secrets and vices, as the criminals he pursues through the underworld.

Marlowe knows this from the first drink, though he needs to verify it in each case, in each mansion, in each client who pays him to find a truth that in reality he would rather not know. It is a peculiar job: being paid to confirm that the world is as wretched as it appeared.

If the privileged are just as rotten as he is — or more — then his own solitude, his cynicism and his glass of cheap whisky acquire an almost heroic glow.

Noir offers an urban version of the same consolation. Marlowe passes through dubious bookshops, gambling salons and smiles born already compromised. He sees heiresses who play with danger, rich men who trade in guilt and criminals who have learned manners. In Los Angeles, downward comparison is not made window by window or office by office. It is made by neighborhood, by accent, by the stains on each suit. That vision grants Marlowe a minimal moral advantage: he goes on walking alone, suit creased, conscience still serviceable.

The failure of others fulfills the function of a preventive rehearsal: it allows us to practice the gesture of survival using someone else's body. We say "what a shame" in the exact tone of someone who has just confirmed that the universe still holds reserves of cruelty to distribute in an orderly fashion. Other people's misfortune becomes a unit of measurement. One learns nothing much but sleeps a little better.



To cultivate the gaze upon another's disaster is a form of collecting. Like all collectors, the practitioner develops over

time a clinical eye: learns to detect the piece before it falls, to assess the state of preservation of a ruin in progress, to distinguish between the provisional disaster and the definitive. When someone succeeds at something, the accomplished enthusiast does not despair; he simply looks immediately for the crack: the hidden debt, the marriage in ruins, the discreet psychotropic that must be sustaining that obscene prosperity. And when someone fails, there comes that special compassion — "it was only a matter of time" — delivered with the expression of a surgeon announcing that there was nothing to be done from the start.

Everyday life offers inexhaustible material. Someone else's separation puts our own marriage in order for a few minutes. A humiliating dismissal converts our mediocre office into an acceptable refuge. An acquaintance's illness converts our ailments into an acceptable form of health.

Envy is comparison when it looks upward. The neighbor's better vacation, the newer, larger or more powerful car, the child who gets better marks or scores more goals, the excessively luminous photograph of someone else's vacation: all demand a secret correction. There will be debt, there will be deception, there will be family pressure, there will be bad taste, there will be some crack that returns the scene to a bearable scale. Envy does not always want to possess what belongs to others; it often settles for the other's good fortune simply ceasing to reproach us. Envy elevates the other while

it wounds us; downward comparison degrades him so that we can breathe. The first does not relax: it points to our inferiority. The second consoles: it confirms that someone below us still remains.

We do not exactly want the other to sink; we want his stability to be challengeable, his advantage to have leaks, his happiness to be unable to look down on us. That desire encompasses our family, our neighborhood, the office, and even our sports club. Comparison needs evidence, and pity is usually the envelope in which we keep it.

To complete the humiliation, the mechanism also works in reverse. Nothing is more dispiriting than discovering that one has become part of someone else's collection. To be observed not as a person, but as a warning. To become that case someone mentions in a low voice in order to feel provisionally saved: "at least I am not like him." Then misfortune acquires a second humiliation. It is no longer enough to suffer it; one must also serve as a scale. One loses one's job, one's partner, one's health or one's composure, and immediately one senses how a small waiting list forms in the vicinity: others breathe more easily because, for now, it is someone else's turn.

We believe we are observing others and in reality discover that we too have a number. Every neighboring ruin functions as a number in the queue for disaster. We are consoled to

know that someone is ahead of us. The relief is born of a postponement, of a bureaucracy of misfortune. While the neighbor burns, we think that the fire respects the order of arrival.

So: contemplate the misfortunes of others with gratitude. They are gifts for you.

Chapter 16

A Little Light, or the Elegance of Illuminating the Irreparable

You have made it this far, which means that something in all of this has felt familiar to you. Not the argument in the abstract: some specific mechanism, some character too recognizable, some sentence that one ought not to read aloud. That is not a compliment. It is a diagnosis.

We have travelled through three of the territories where we deploy our talent for complicating our own existence with the greatest conviction: frustration, conflict, and uncertainty. They do not act separately. They are communicating vessels: when the pressure rises in one, the other two feel it. Frustration does not need to pass through conflict to arrive at uncertainty. Conflict does not wait for instructions. Uncertainty does not distinguish where the weight comes from. The liquid moves on its own.

What they have in common is not the discomfort, but what we do with it: we find responses that provide relief, that buy time, that sometimes even win the battle. And repeated with sufficient conviction they make worse exactly what they were meant to fix. As in ballet: repetition does not perfect the movement. It fixes it.

These are not, of course, the only territories of disaster. The map of our misery is far wider, far more irregular: illnesses

wait for us there, catastrophes, and so many other things life is pleased to bestow upon us. But these three patches are more than enough to make our existence unbearable. We face them as best we can — generally badly — applying inherited solutions or inventing our own ineptitudes.

We go to the cinema and to literature as one visits a war zone from an armored bus: we can contemplate other people's disaster without paying for it in our own flesh. A character has one decisive advantage over us: they demand no defense. We can watch how they make mistakes, how they rationalize, how they confuse caprice with destiny and flight with a sophisticated decision.

The work, unlike existence, is a distillate. Borges imagined Funes, a man condemned to remember everything: his perfect memory prevented him from abstracting, because to abstract is to forget differences, and he could not afford to forget anything. Literature does what Funes could not: it distils, compresses, converts experience into pattern. Like a clear aguardiente that no longer remembers the grain it came from. The error of the other is exposed with a clarity that no biography sustains, one's own or another's.

It is likely that you have seen yourself reflected in one of the mechanisms. Do not feel special. We all practice some form of elegant sabotage. The line between the person who manages the disaster and the one who succumbs to it is not a

question of moral integrity, but of whether you retain that small clarity sufficient to detect the precise instant at which you begin to lie to yourself.

These mechanisms deserve something better than contempt. They work. Not well, not for long, and certainly not for free, but they work. They buy a few minutes of air. They reduce the sharpness. They shift the blame. They convert a wound into a narrative and an impotence into a posture. They are poor solutions. They come from a hurried form of intelligence: that of the cornered animal that needs a truce now, not an admirable truth in six months' time. One does not always choose the worst out of perversity. Sometimes one is simply in a hurry.

They do not wait for permission. They kick in on their own, before you have decided anything, with the punctuality of a reflex inscribed in biology or carved by the years. What the small clarity introduces is not a brake: it is a fraction of a second between the automatism and its justification. Sometimes that is enough to hear the machinery before it accelerates. Sometimes, even, to choose which of the available mechanisms you are going to use to make your mistake.

That fraction of a second does not save. It does not convert the error into a lesson nor the disaster into a formative experience. It makes the damage more legible, which is not

the same thing. If your ambition was complete salvation, you have wandered into the wrong aisle of the bookshop.

The book I wanted to write was another one. A positive one. What happened is that I do not know how to write it. And perhaps it is not only incapacity: without the pressure of suffering we would probably not do much. Not write anything, in fact.

Why don't you try writing it yourself? I would buy it.